

The Firefly Lanterns

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.*

Before you begin

Tonight was the night of the summer Lantern Festival, the warmest night of all the year in the Lantern Village. Every summer the paper lanterns came alive with light, and the whole village danced beneath them, the little ones chasing each other between the glowing rows while the drums beat soft and slow. But this year, as dusk settled over the terraced rice fields, the lanterns hung grey and dark, and not a single one would light.

The reason was a gentle one, and a little sad. Inside each paper lantern lived a shy Firefly Spirit, and it was their soft light that made the lanterns glow. Tonight, every one of them had slipped away to hide. They had flown up into the Whispering Bamboo Grove, deep among the dark stalks, far too timid to come out and shine.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper, who knew every story the mountains had ever told, called the two of you to her side. "You have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more on a night like this than any lantern-pole. Will you climb to the grove and coax the firefly spirits gently home, so our festival can glow again?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a round paper lantern on a little handle, a ball of bright red thread, and a soft, sweet rice cake wrapped in a leaf. "Remember," she said, her eyes crinkling, "up in these hills we never win by being loud or strong. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry tonight: Imagination, Courage, or Kindness?*

Stop 1 The Dark Bamboo

The path wound up through the cool evening to the Whispering Bamboo Grove, where the tall green stalks clicked and swayed and whispered together in the wind. Inside it was dark and very, very still. Here and there a tiny light blinked on, then vanished, then blinked somewhere new, like stars that could not decide whether to come out. The firefly spirits were close. But they were shy, and the smallest sound sent them flickering away.

From the green shadows stepped a russet fox with bright, lively eyes and a single leaf balanced on his head. It was Kon the Fox, who loved a good game and a kind heart, and he gave you a slow, friendly wink, as if to say there was no hurry at all.

★ *The spirits are timid, and timid friends cannot be chased. What gentle thing could you try? Could you move slowly and keep your voices soft? You carry a sweet rice cake to offer. Could you simply sit still and patient, and let the little lights choose to come to you?*

So you grew quiet and calm, and waited. One small light drifted near, then hovered, then settled. Another followed, and another, until a whole soft cloud of golden fireflies floated all around you, warm against your cheeks, no longer the least bit afraid. "Well done," whispered

Kon, his tail curling with pleasure. "They trust you now. They will follow where you lead."

Stop 2 The Lantern Path

The fireflies would come home with you, the fox explained, but only if every step felt safe. A long path of empty paper lanterns ran down the hillside to the village, and if you could light them in the right order, a gentle road of light would open up and lead the shy spirits all the way down.

But in what order? The lanterns stood in many sizes, some no bigger than a teacup and some as round as the moon, and your ball of red thread ran from one to the next, tying the whole line softly together.

★ *How will you light them so the spirits never take fright? You might go from the smallest lantern to the very biggest, a path that grows as gently as the dawn. You might simply follow the red thread from lantern to lantern. Or you might ask Kon the Fox, who knows these paths well, for a quiet hint. What is your plan?*

When you found the gentle order and touched each lantern alight, one after another, a soft golden road unrolled down the hill. The little fireflies bobbed along it in a happy ribbon of light, following close behind you, every step of the way a step they were not afraid to take.

Stop 3 The Great Lantern

At the top of the festival square stood the Great Lantern, taller than a grown-up and rounder than a barrel, the heart of the whole festival. To light it, the very shyest firefly of all had to fly up inside and shine. But this little spirit was the most timid of them all. It hung back at your shoulder, trembling, gazing up at the great dark lantern as if it were a mountain too high to climb.

This was never a fight, and there was nothing here to beat. The little firefly only needed to find, somewhere inside itself, a small and steady scrap of courage.

★ *What could you say to help it feel brave? You might speak in the softest, calmest voice you have. You might tell it that you believe in it, and that you will be right here watching the whole time. You might gently remind it how brave it has already been. What do you try?*

When you cheered it on, warm and unhurried, the little firefly drew in a tiny breath, lifted from your shoulder, and flew up into the dark. For a heartbeat there was nothing. Then the Great Lantern bloomed with light, the warmest and brightest of them all, and the little firefly glowed at its very heart, no longer afraid.

The Festival Glows

One by one, all across the village, every lantern caught the light and glowed a deep, happy gold, until the dark was chased clean away. The firefly spirits swirled out into the warm night air and danced, looping and spinning in bright circles above the rooftops, not a shy bone left among them.

The whole village burst into cheers and laughter, and the dancing began. The drums beat soft and warm, the lanterns swayed like a low sky full of small, kind moons, and Kon the Fox watched from a rooftop with his eyes shining.

And when at last the morning came, warm Amaterasu the Sun-Kami rose gently over the blossom mountains and smiled down upon the valley. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your imagination, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the blossom mountains.

The Firefly Lanterns: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale, soft and warm from start to finish, and no one is ever frightened or hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Lantern Village.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a paper cup or anything round for the paper lantern, a ball of red string or wool for the red thread, and any small token for the rice cake. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On a night like this, no hero shines alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Kon the Fox slips from the bamboo and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your calm again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts down the hill, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Guardian Lion-Dogs nod kindly from the gate. All is well.
5	A lucky cherry petal lands on your shoulder: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The soft ring of a temple bell, and for a moment everyone feels calm and brave.

How it ends

The shyest little firefly at the Great Lantern is the last "challenge", but it is no foe. It is simply a small spirit that feels too timid to shine. The tale is won not by pushing it but by encouraging it with a calm and kindly word, and the festival blazes into light. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Firefly Lanterns: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Dark Bamboo (Easy)

The challenge. The Firefly Spirits are hiding in the dark of the Whispering Bamboo Grove, blinking on and off and darting away. They are gentle but very shy, and they cannot be caught or chased.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Observation moment. The caring move is to slow right down: move gently, keep voices soft, sit still, and offer the sweet **rice cake** so the spirits feel safe enough to come close on their own. Patience and a quiet, friendly manner are what win them over, not speed.

Fallback. If the children grow restless or try to grab the lights, have **Kon the Fox** murmur, "They come to calm hearts, not quick hands," and show them how to sit still. The moment they settle and wait kindly, a firefly drifts down to them, and the rest follow. A gentle try always works.

Stop 2: The Lantern Path (Normal)

The challenge. A long row of empty paper lanterns leads down the hill to the village. The players must light them in an order gentle enough that the shy spirits will feel safe to follow.

Intended solution. This is an Imagination, Logic and Observation moment. The thoughtful move is to find a calm, clear pattern: lighting from the **smallest lantern to the biggest** so the path grows gently, or simply following the **red thread** that ties the lanterns in their proper line from one to the next. Any thought-through order that the children can explain works just as well.

Fallback. If they are unsure where to start, let the **red thread** show the way (follow it bead by bead), or have **Kon the Fox** point his nose down the line with a hint. They may also spend an energy star to "remember" the pattern. Getting there with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Great Lantern (Normal)

The challenge. The Great Lantern at the top of the square must be lit by the shyest little firefly of all, but this one is too timid and hangs back, trembling. The players may want to push or hurry it. They should not.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. The little firefly only needs encouragement. Any genuine, calming kindness works: speaking in a soft and steady voice, saying "I believe in you" and "I will be right here", or reminding it how brave it has already been tonight. When the children cheer it on gently, it gathers its courage, flies up, and the Great Lantern blooms with the warmest light of all.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or try to nudge the firefly up by force, have it shrink back and whisper, "Will you stay with me?" A single kind, calm word is enough. The moment the players offer any warm encouragement at all, the little spirit finds its courage and the great lantern lights.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the Great Lantern lights, every lantern in the village glows gold, the firefly spirits dance free in the warm night, and the whole village cheers and

begins the festival. By morning, warm **Amaterasu the Sun-Kami** rises and smiles down on the valley. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Version 3.4, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.